The Memo

DAILY INTELLIGENCE BRIEF

SATURDAY, MARCH 21, 2026

NO. 0016

Executive Summary

[Iran escalation] Iran struck UK's Diego Garcia base, exceeding known missile range. Selectively opens Hormuz for grain and allied vessels. See World Affairs.

[Oil spike] Brent hit $119 intraweek before settling ~$108–109. Goldman warns prices could top 2008's $147.50 record. See Credit, Rates & Currencies.

[Iraq force majeure] Baghdad declared force majeure on all foreign-operated oilfields. Hormuz disruption blocks crude exports. See Economic & Business Intelligence.

[Fed rate outlook] Markets price 75% chance of a Fed hike by September. Zero cuts expected this year. See Credit, Rates & Currencies.

[ECB tightening] JPMorgan and Barclays pencil in three ECB hikes — April, June, July — to 2.75%. See Credit, Rates & Currencies.

[Private credit stress] Blackstone flagship credit fund posts first monthly loss since 2022. Private credit spreads widen 25–50bp. See Private Equity.

[Pentagon AI] Palantir's Maven AI wins formal 'program of record' status. Embedded in long-term DoD combat budgets. See AI & Technology.

[Data center mega-bet] SoftBank's Son unveils plan for a single $500B gas-powered data center campus in Ohio. See AI & Technology.

[PE exits] Ecolab acquires KKR-backed CoolIT for $4.75B. Abbott set to close $21B Exact Sciences deal Monday. See Private Equity.

[IPO window] Janus Living jumps 18% after $840M IPO — largest US listing this week. Tangible-asset story cuts through war volatility. See IPO & Exit Climate.

Credit, Rates & Currencies

NEW **[JPMorgan, Barclays Pencil In Three ECB Hikes — April, June, July]** Deposit rate would reach 2.75% by year-end. Morgan Stanley expects two hikes to 2.5%. Nagel warned the ECB must act if second-round effects emerge. April hike discussion confirmed. If April hike materialises, BTP spreads widen sharply and European leveraged finance pipelines stall through Q2.

Sources: CNBC; Reuters

DAY 2 **[US 10-Year Yield Surges to 4.39% — 12–15bp Selloff Across the Curve]** *War-driven inflation fears sparked broad bond selloff; markets began pricing a Fed hike.* Friday's rout sent yields 12–15bp higher. Money markets now see zero chance of a 2026 cut. WSJ report of additional warships triggered the sharpest move. Previously: War-driven inflation fears drove a broad bond selloff. Markets began pricing a moderate chance the Fed hikes later this year. Parallel rise across the curve reflects funding-condition stress. Expect IG and HY widening over 2–4 weeks if 10-year holds above 4.3%.

Sources: Bloomberg; Kitco/Reuters

Global Conflict Monitor

MIDDLE EAST

[Israel-Iran War] ▲ Escalating

Parties: United States, Israel vs. Iran; Gulf states caught in crossfire

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: Day 22. Trump floated 'winding down' but ordered thousands more troops including USS Boxer and 11th MEU. Iran developing Hormuz 'vetting system' — selective passage for India, Japan, China, Pakistan, Iraq, Malaysia. Japan passage confirmed via Kyodo. US-Israel struck Natanz nuclear site. Iran used cluster warheads on central Israel, wounding civilians in Rehovot. Iraq declared force majeure on all foreign-operated oilfields. Iran threatened to target Israeli/US officials in global 'tourist and entertainment centers.' Brent spiked to ~$119 before retreating to ~$110. IEA urged consumers to cut driving. Qatar's Ras Laffan damage confirmed as multi-year outage. US temporarily waived sanctions on Iranian oil at sea.

Risk Assessment: Trump's 'wind down' contradicts expanding deployments. Iran's selective Hormuz transit creates a two-tier shipping regime favoring non-Western nations. Iraq's force majeure locks out IOCs from ~4.5 Mb/d. Brent likely range-bound $105–120 over 2–4 weeks. Fertilizer up 30–40%, threatening spring planting. Defense equities benefit from surge orders.

Sources: Bloomberg; Al Jazeera; Bloomberg; Reuters; Reuters; Al Jazeera; Times of Israel †

[Israel-Lebanon / Hezbollah] ▲ Escalating

Parties: Israel vs. Hezbollah

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: Israel continuing ground incursion. IDF struck Hezbollah financial and military sites; 14 dead reported. Hezbollah maintained rocket attacks; sirens in Galilee. Kuwait and UAE disrupted domestic Hezbollah cells. Crisis Group warns the war leaves Lebanon near ruin.

Risk Assessment: Second front strains Israeli military amid the Iran campaign. Lebanese sovereign debt and regional insurance premiums face further pressure over 4–6 weeks.

Sources: Crisis Group †; Long War Journal †; Times of Israel †

[Iraq — Iran-Backed Militia Strikes] ▬ Ongoing

Parties: United States vs. Iran-backed Iraqi militias

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: US airstrikes continued targeting Iran-backed militias. One strike reportedly killed a senior Kataib Hezbollah commander. US and Kataib Hezbollah agreed to a temporary pause on US Embassy attacks. Iraq declared force majeure on all foreign-operated oilfields.

Risk Assessment: Embassy ceasefire reduces immediate diplomatic risk but does not resolve the proxy war. Iraq's force majeure locks out IOCs and compounds the global supply crisis.

Sources: Long War Journal †; Reuters

[Syria — Israeli Strikes on Government Sites] ▬ Ongoing

Parties: Israel vs. Syrian government

Region: Middle East

Latest Development: Israel struck Syrian weapons sites and government infrastructure. Syria condemned the strikes as an 'outrageous' assault on sovereignty.

Risk Assessment: Another front in the regional conflagration. Multi-front escalation vectors compound over 2–4 weeks.

Source: BBC

EUROPE

[Ukraine-Russia War] ▲ Escalating

Parties: Ukraine vs. Russia

Region: Europe

Latest Development: Ukraine began compulsory evacuation of children from Sloviansk as Russia advanced to 20km. Ukraine exploited Russian Starlink blackout to launch southern offensive. Zelenskyy sent delegation to seek US talks resumption. ISW confirmed Ukrainian advances near Hulyaipole. US Patriot missiles redeployed from Europe to Middle East, leaving gaps. Ukraine deployed 200+ drone-defense experts to five Gulf states. Hungary pipeline dispute threatens EU €90B loan.

Risk Assessment: Iran war directly degrading Ukraine's defense posture through Patriot redeployments. Over 4–8 weeks, expect intensified Russian ground operations in Donetsk while Western alliance cohesion faces its most severe test since the full-scale invasion.

Sources: WSJ; The Guardian †; AP News; ISW †; Military.com †; BBC

ASIA

[Afghanistan-Pakistan Border Conflict] ▲ Escalating

Parties: Pakistan vs. Afghan Taliban

Region: Asia

Latest Development: Mass-casualty incident near Kabul on March 16 marks a significant escalation. Both sides trading fire. Crisis Group warns continued fighting promises only death, displacement, and economic damage.

Risk Assessment: Most dangerous Pakistan-Taliban flare-up since US withdrawal. Risk of border crossing closures disrupting Central/South Asian trade over 2–4 weeks.

Sources: Crisis Group †; Hasht-e Subh Daily †

[Taiwan Strait Tensions] ▬ Stable

Parties: China vs. Taiwan (US security guarantor)

Region: Asia

Latest Development: Chinese warplane sorties toward Taiwan decreased over three weeks. Analysts cite fuel costs, desire to avoid provoking Trump, and political meetings. US intel assesses no China invasion plan by 2027. Taiwan concerned over US missile depletion. CNN reports delayed Xi-Trump summit strengthens Beijing's hand.

Risk Assessment: Near-term invasion risk decreased. Structural risk rising. US munitions drawdowns erode Taiwan Strait deterrence. Key variable over 3–6 months: US defense industrial replenishment pace.

Sources: Defense News; FT; CNN

AFRICA

[Horn of Africa — Multiple Crises] ▬ Ongoing

Parties: Multiple: regional state actors, armed groups, jihadist insurgencies

Region: Africa

Latest Development: 26 million face 'extreme hunger' across Kenya, Ethiopia, Somalia. US weighing Somaliland recognition for strategic basing. Nigeria's jihadist threat worsening in the north.

Risk Assessment: Iran war diverting US assets and attention. Fertilizer price spikes from Hormuz compound food insecurity. Conditions likely deteriorate over 4–8 weeks.

Sources: BBC; Crisis Group †

World Affairs

NEW **[Iranian Navy Guided Indian LNG Tanker Through Hormuz — Bilateral Deal]** Senior officer onboard confirmed Iran gave passage after Tehran-New Delhi negotiations. Follows similar offer to Japan. Selective-access strategy expanding to major Asian importers. India joins Japan in bilateral Hormuz deals. Each deal weakens Trump's multilateral pressure campaign. South Korea likely next.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Iran Warns UAE Against Allowing Attacks From Disputed Gulf Islands]** Tehran warned Abu Dhabi against permitting operations from Abu Musa and Greater Tunb. Iran-controlled but UAE-claimed islands sit near Hormuz. Direct Iranian threat to UAE territory raises stakes for Gulf neutrals. If UAE is drawn in, Saudi follows. Watch for US basing pressure on Abu Dhabi.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[Norway Warns NATO Must Hold All Flanks as US Focuses on Iran]** Norwegian defense minister said the alliance must avoid retrenchment. US Middle East focus creating gaps in European posture. European anxiety over US force diversion to Iran will accelerate defense spending momentum over the next 6 months.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Merz Plans Trump Call While Doubling Down on MAGA Criticism]** German Chancellor distanced himself again from Trump's base. Plans continued engagement despite public criticism. Balancing domestic anti-war sentiment with alliance management. Merz threading a narrow line. German industry needs stable transatlantic relations. Watch for trade concessions as substitute for military support.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Putin Congratulates Iran on Nowruz — 'Loyal Friend and Reliable Partner']** Kremlin pledged friendship. Iranian sources say they received little real help. Gap between rhetoric and material support persists. Russia-Iran alignment remains transactional, not strategic. Iran increasingly isolated militarily despite diplomatic solidarity.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[IRGC Rebuilt Hezbollah's Military Command After 2024 Israeli Strikes]** Iran's Revolutionary Guards plugged gaps with Iranian officers after Israel decimated Hezbollah leadership. Restructured the group for the current war. Confirms Hezbollah's 2024 decapitation was temporary. IRGC reconstitution creates the multi-front dynamic Israel sought to prevent.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[Palantir's Maven AI Wins Pentagon 'Program of Record' Status]** DoD establishing Maven as a formal program of record. Wartime adoption accelerating procurement timelines. Program-of-record status guarantees sustained funding. Iran war serving as live testbed for AI-enabled targeting. Palantir's defense revenue trajectory materially strengthened.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Israel Reportedly Strikes Iran's Natanz Nuclear Site as Iranians Mark Eid]** Al-Monitor reports a US-Israeli strike on Natanz. Fresh strikes also hit Tehran on Nowruz/Eid. Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei remains out of public view. Natanz is Iran's primary enrichment facility. Significant damage would set back nuclear capability years — a core war objective. Escalation makes diplomatic off-ramps harder.

Source: Al-Monitor †

NEW **[US Embassies and Consulates Hit by Missile and Drone Strikes — No Injuries]** Series of strikes caused limited damage. No US personnel injured. Attacks underscore expanded Iranian targeting beyond the theater. If injuries occur, domestic US pressure for ground operations intensifies dramatically. Iran calibrating below the casualty threshold for now.

Source: WSJ

DAY 2 **[Trump Floats Wind-Down Again — Strikes on Tehran and Beirut Continue]** *Trump said Friday the US was considering 'winding down.' He rejected a ceasefire. Pentagon ordered 2,000+ Marines to the region.* Israel struck Tehran and Beirut Saturday. $2B/day cost cited by Rep. Ro Khanna. Contradiction persists. Previously: Trump said Friday the US was considering 'winding down' military efforts. He rejected a ceasefire. Pentagon ordered 2,000+ additional Marines to the region. White House weighing Kharg Island seizure plan. Wind-down language repeated twice without matching action. Markets should treat as political positioning. Ground truth: deployments expanding, strikes intensifying, Hormuz still closed.

Sources: Bloomberg; Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Iran's Selective Hormuz Access Expands — India Joins Japan]** *FM Araghchi offered Japan safe passage. Countries attacking Iran face restrictions.* Iranian navy guided an Indian LPG tanker through after bilateral talks. Coalition-splitting strategy now covers two of the world's largest energy importers. Previously: FM Araghchi offered Japan safe passage. Denied closing strait entirely. Countries attacking Iran face restrictions; others offered assistance. Each bilateral deal fragments the unified Western response. Selective access undermines the narrative of total Hormuz closure. South Korea likely next.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[US Treasury's 30-Day Iranian Oil License — Bessent Confirms]** *30-day license covers Iranian crude already on tankers. Trump's UN ambassador called it 'very temporary.'* Bessent confirmed on X. Administration framing as price-cap measure. Previously: 30-day license covers Iranian-origin crude already loaded on tankers. Move aims to cap fuel prices. Trump's UN ambassador called it 'very temporary.' Finite tanker volumes provide marginal relief. Signals administration alarm at diesel above $5. Watch for rolling extension if Hormuz stays contested.

Sources: Newsweek; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Iran's 10M Rial Note — New Supreme Leader Remains Out of Public View]** *Highest-ever denomination bill introduced. Iranians queuing for hard currency.* Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei has not appeared publicly since succeeding his killed father. Previously: Highest-ever denomination bill introduced. Iranians queuing for hard currency as strikes fuel demand. Supreme Leader's absence from Eid prayers fuels questions about regime stability. Monetary collapse and leadership opacity compound uncertainty.

Sources: FT; Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Taiwan Missile Concern Validated — Norway Also Flags NATO Deterrence Gap]** *Weapons expended in the Gulf would be crucial in early phases of any China conflict.* Norway's defense minister warned NATO must avoid retrenchment. Dual-front gap now acknowledged by Indo-Pacific and European allies. Previously: Weapons expended in the Gulf would be crucial in early phases of any conflict with China. Taiwan highlighted second-order security costs. US defense industrial base faces 18–24 month replenishment timeline. China and Russia benefit simultaneously.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Zombie Ship Tactics Confirmed — Transit Strategies Evolving]** *A vessel assumed the identity of a scrapped gas carrier to transit Hormuz.* Bloomberg confirms strategies are evolving as war progresses. Identity spoofing expanding. Previously: A vessel assuming the identity of a scrapped gas carrier transited the strait. Bloomberg reported

evolving transit strategies. Maritime insurers and sanctions enforcers face growing evasion challenge. AIS verification tightening likely accelerated.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Iran Regime Holds — Hard-Liner Eyed to Replace Slain Security Chief Larijani]** *Western intel assessed regime not close to falling. Iran unwilling to discuss Hormuz while under attack.* Al-Monitor reports a potential hard-line successor to Ali Larijani. Choice may determine confrontation trajectory. Previously: Western intel assessed the regime is not close to falling. Officials coalescing around remaining leaders. Iran unwilling to discuss Hormuz reopening while under attack. Larijani replacement is the single most important personnel indicator for conflict trajectory over the next 4 weeks.

Source: Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[Trump-Xi Delay Strengthens Beijing's Hand — China Reads War as Weakness]** *Late-March summit postponed as Iran dominates. China's soybean purchases stalled.* CNN reports Beijing sees Trump entering talks weakened. Supreme Court tariff ruling and prolonged campaign erode US leverage. Previously: Late-March summit postponed as Iran dominates. China's soybean purchases stalled after meeting initial 12M-ton pledge. 6–8 week diplomatic vacuum benefits Beijing. Agricultural exporters face renewed uncertainty as Brazil positions as alternative supplier.

Sources: CNN; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[China Export Restrictions — Fuel and Fertilizer Curbs Confirmed]** *China began restricting fuel and fertilizer exports amid elevated energy prices.* Beijing limiting sales abroad to preserve domestic stockpiles. Previously: China began restricting fuel and fertilizer exports amid elevated energy prices. Export curbs compound global fertilizer tightness. South and Southeast Asian agricultural economies face input cost spikes into planting season.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Panama Canal at Max — Preparing Daily LNG Slots vs. Four Per Month Prior]** *Canal operating at top capacity. LNG tanker demand surging from US ports.* One LNG slot per day being prepared, up from four per month. Previously: Canal operating at top capacity. LNG tanker demand surging from US ports. Panama bottleneck compounds Hormuz and Suez disruptions. Canal capacity is a hard physical constraint with no quick fix.

Source: Al-Monitor †

DAY 2 **[SPR Barrels Flowing — Diesel Passes $5/Gallon for Second Time in History]** *Oil from 172M-barrel emergency release set to start flowing.* Diesel surpassed $5 nationally — only second time ever. Fuel powers trucking, farming, construction. Previously: Oil from Trump's emergency release set to start flowing. 172M-barrel draw is latest effort to contain fuel prices. SPR provides marginal relief against structural supply loss. Diesel at $5 hits trucking, agriculture, and construction margins immediately.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Poilievre Pitches Canadian Trade Leverage — Oil Sands Face Production Hurdles]** *Poilievre appeared on Rogan to sell Canada's trade position.* IEA supply pledge faces seasonal maintenance, pipeline constraints, and wildfire risk. Previously: Poilievre appeared on The Joe Rogan Experience to sell Canada's trade position to US audiences. Markets should discount Canada's supply pledge by 30–40% on operational realities. Poilievre positioning ahead of election.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Takaichi's No-Commitment Strategy Validated — Iran Offers Japan Passage]** *Takaichi visited Washington under pressure. Offered no military support. Trump praised Japan anyway.* Iran's bilateral deal confirms the diplomatic gambit paid off. Previously: Japanese PM Takaichi visited Washington under pressure to support Hormuz

operations. Trump praised Japan but Takaichi offered no direct military support. Japan's model — praise Trump, refuse troops, cut bilateral deal with Iran — becomes the template for non-belligerent US allies.

Sources: The Diplomat †; Bloomberg

DAY 4 **[Iran-Israel Mutual Restraint on Energy — But Tehran Warns UAE Over Islands]** *White House convinced Israel not to strike South Pars again; Tehran spares Qatar.* Now Iran threatening UAE over Abu Musa and Greater Tunb. Fragile equilibrium expanding to new fault lines. Previously: White House convinced Israel not to attack South Pars again on condition Tehran does not target Qatar. Mutual-vulnerability bargaining established. Energy quid pro quo holding but UAE threat opens a new front. Each Gulf state drawn in multiplies escalation pathways.

Sources: Foreign Policy †; Al-Monitor †

Art & Auction Intelligence

NEW **[Greek Divers Recover Parthenon Fragment From Lord Elgin's Shipwreck]** Underwater antiquities unit found the marble piece in summer 2025. Fragment likely from the 5th-century B.C.E. temple's ornamental crown. Excavation exposed the Mentor's decomposed hull. Adds ammunition to Greece's restitution argument against the British Museum. Expect renewed diplomatic pressure on London.

Source: Artnet News

NEW **[Man Destroys Chihuly Sculptures in Seattle — $240K in Damage]** Alexander Weis caused catastrophic damage at Chihuly Garden and Glass Monday evening. Multiple glass sculptures destroyed. Weis in custody. Raises institutional security questions for fragile high-value installations. Insurance premiums for glass art may tighten.

Source: Artforum

NEW **[Whitney Biennial Draws Tepid Critical Reception]** Hyperallergic called the show "for the faint-hearted." Critic: "This biennial is hiding from the world today instead of reflecting on it." Tepid reviews can suppress collector engagement with featured emerging artists over the 6-month run.

Source: Hyperallergic

NEW **[Never-Before-Seen Van Dyck Paintings Shown in Major Genoa Exhibition]** Exhibition brings together rare works from Van Dyck's formative Italian period. Focus on how Italy shaped his signature style. Fresh scholarly attention to Genoa-period works could lift secondary interest in Van Dyck's non-portrait output over 6–12 months.

Source: Artnet News

NEW **[Outsider Art Fair Opens in Manhattan — Broadening 'Outsider' Definition]** Runs through March 22 at Metropolitan Pavilion. ARTnews notes the most wide-ranging definition of 'outsider' yet. Sam Doyle's narrative portraits on found wood highlighted. Expanding category boundaries reflects collector appetite for autodidact and vernacular art. Doyle's works command growing institutional interest.

Sources: ARTnews; The Art Newspaper

NEW **[Jordan Wolfson Creates Prada SS26 Campaign — Giant Birds Stalk Models]** Artist known for unsettling animatronics directs ad featuring Carey Mulligan and Nicholas Hoult. Luxury houses increasingly commissioning contemporary artists. Wolfson's commercial crossover amplifies gallery visibility — watch secondary prices on sculpture editions.

Sources: ARTnews; Artnet News

NEW **[Cecily Brown 'Picture Making' Opens March 27 at Serpentine, London]** New paintings alongside works dating to 2001. Follows Brown's acclaimed 2022 Met exhibition. Auction record topped $6.7M. Serpentine survey typically lifts secondary demand. Watch spring auction lots.

Source: Artsy

NEW **[London National Gallery Visitor Numbers Still Below Pre-Covid Levels]** Despite renovation boost, attendance has not recovered. Natural History Museum overtakes British Museum as UK's most-visited. Structural attendance decline signals lasting post-pandemic behavioral shift. Implications for sponsorship valuations across the UK cultural sector.

Source: The Art Newspaper

DAY 2 **[Christie's Tests Chinese Appetite With Early Van Gogh — $1.3M–$2.6M]** *A Girl in a Wood (1883) goes to auction. Last sold for $670K in 2002. Half of Van Goghs now go to Chinese buyers.* Sale confirmed March 27 during Art Basel Hong Kong week. Previously: A Girl in a Wood (1883) goes to auction. Last sold for $670K in 2002. Half of Van Goghs at auction now go to Chinese buyers. Sub-$3M estimate positions this as a gateway lot for newer Chinese collectors. Art Basel Hong Kong timing maximizes bidder pool.

Source: The Art Newspaper

DAY 2 **[Irsay Guitar Market Reset — Electric Guitars Enter Stradivarius Territory]** *Irsay collection hit $94.5M at Christie's. Guitar sales: $84M. Gilmour Strat $14.5M, Garcia $11.5M, Cobain Mustang $6.9M.* Three instruments above $6.9M in a single sale. Previously: Jim Irsay's pop culture collection achieved $94.5M at Christie's. Guitar sales alone: $84M. Gilmour's 1969 Strat hit $14.5M, Garcia's Doug Irwin $11.5M, Cobain's Mustang $6.9M. Repricing is structural. Expect auction houses to build dedicated rock memorabilia departments within 12 months.

Source: Artnet News

DAY 2 **[206 Vivian Maier Prints Offered as Single Lot — Market Test]** *206 sold-out prints appear in Artnet's Important Photographs sale.* Trove could rewrite Maier's secondary market by concentrating supply. Previously: 206 sold-out prints appear in Artnet's Important Photographs sale. Could reset pricing by concentrating supply in one transaction. Result benchmarks estate-controlled edition pricing going forward.

Source: Artnet News

DAY 2 **[Zurich's Museum Rietberg Transfers 11 Benin Bronzes to Nigeria]** *Rietberg transferred title of 11 Benin Bronzes to Nigerian government. Nine stay in Zurich.* Hybrid custody model continues. Previously: Rietberg transferred title of 11 Benin Bronzes to Nigerian government. Nine stay in Zurich. Hybrid custody-plus-title model emerging as European consensus for provenance claims.

Source: The Art Newspaper

DAY 2 **[Venice Mayor Warns Russia Pavilion — Pussy Riot Responds]** *Mayor Brugnaro warned Russia's pavilion will be shut if it features propaganda.* Pussy Riot called the proposed 'dissent' curation "performative." Offered to participate if invitation is genuine. Previously: Mayor Brugnaro warned Russia's pavilion will be shut if it features propaganda. Said Biennale should remain a platform for diplomacy. Actual closure of the Russian Pavilion would be unprecedented. Political temperature rising ahead of the 2026 edition.

Source: The Art Newspaper

DAY 2 **[Calvin Tomkins, New Yorker Art Critic, Dead at 100]** *Tomkins chronicled generations of vanguard artists. Duchamp biography and New Yorker profiles shaped how collectors understood postwar art for five decades.* Tributes continue. Previously: Tomkins chronicled generations of vanguard artists. His Duchamp biography and New Yorker profiles shaped how collectors understood postwar art for five decades. Expect collector and institutional tributes to drive renewed interest in Tomkins-profiled artists over coming weeks.

Source: ARTnews

DAY 2 **[Murdoch–MCH Ideas Festival — 2028 Launch Target Confirmed]** *James Murdoch and Art Basel parent MCH planning a large-scale ideas festival.* Details sparse on format and location. Previously: James Murdoch and Art Basel parent MCH Group planning a large-scale ideas festival. MCH diversifying beyond fair model signals revenue pressure on traditional formats. Watch for venue announcements.

Source: ARTnews

DAY 2 **[Irving Penn Portraits Head to Christie's New York — April 3]** *Portraits of Picasso, Noguchi, Didion, Dalí. Part of spring photography auction.* Prints use platinum and palladium techniques. Previously: Portraits of

Picasso, Noguchi, Didion, and Dalí. Part of spring photography auction continuing online through April 17. Penn's platinum-palladium prints hold strong institutional demand. Celebrity subjects drive crossover bidding.

Source: Artsy

DAY 2 **[Czech Culture Minister Dismisses Prague National Gallery Director]** *Czech culture minister dismissed the director, generating scrutiny over political interference.* Alicja Knast said she was "somewhat surprised." No successor named. Previously: Czech culture minister dismissed the director of Prague's National Gallery, generating scrutiny over political interference. Political dismissals signal cultural policy volatility in Central Europe. Collectors may reassess programming partnerships pending successor.

Source: ARTnews

DAY 2 **[Met Acquires Long-Lost Rosso Fiorentino — Earliest Known Work]** *Met acquired the painting, thought lost for centuries. Conservation removed overpaint.* Madonna and Child with Saint John the Evangelist confirmed as earliest known Rosso. Previously: Met acquired the painting, thought lost for centuries. Conservation removed overpaint revealing the original. Strengthens Met's Renaissance holdings. Rediscovery narrative adds institutional prestige.

Source: Artnet News

DAY 2 **[Dalí's 'Necrophiliac Spring' — V&A Show Opens March 28]** *1936 Dalí painting inspired Schiaparelli's 'Tears Dress.' Sold at Sotheby's for $16.3M in 2012. UK debut at V&A.* Curators uncovered a 1953 Life magazine photograph showing the work in Schiaparelli's Paris home. Previously: 1936 Dalí painting inspired Schiaparelli's 'Tears Dress.' Sold at Sotheby's for $16.3M in 2012. Making UK debut at V&A. New provenance documentation strengthens exhibition history. Fashion-art crossover shows consistently drive blockbuster V&A attendance.

Source: The Art Newspaper

DAY 3 **[New Museum Expansion Draws Mixed Critical Reception]** *Opened March 21 with 732 works across 56 countries. Doubled gallery space via OMA expansion.* Hyperallergic asks: "What's so new about the New Museum building?" $82M expansion debuted to divided reviews. Previously: New Museum opened March 21 with 732 works across 56 countries. Doubled gallery space via OMA expansion. Mixed reviews test whether the brand survives prestige-scale expansion. Q2 visitor numbers will determine if $82M investment translates.

Sources: Hyperallergic; The Art Newspaper

Design, UX & Industrial

NEW **[OPEN Architecture Completes Rammed-Earth Museum in Shehong, China]** Shede Culture Museum rises from a water-based landscape. Rammed earth, glass, and bronze shape the complex. OPEN's material palette positions the firm alongside Wang Shu in advancing vernacular Chinese construction for cultural programmes.

Source: DesignBoom

NEW **[UIA 2026 Barcelona Reveals Programme — Six Thematic 'Becomings']** World Congress of Architects returns 28 June–2 July. ~10,000 participants from 130+ countries. Events across Mediterranean seafront venues. First major UIA congress in Barcelona since 1996. Programme signals profession-wide pivot toward climate transition as organising framework.

Source: ArchDaily

NEW **[SAGA Space Architects — Moon Habitat, Mars Shelter, Underwater Structure]** Danish studio built a moon habitat tested in the Arctic, a Mars shelter running on dust storms, and an underwater structure in Copenhagen harbour. Defence and space agencies increasingly contract small studios for habitat prototyping. SAGA's tested portfolio positions it for procurement cycles.

Source: DesignBoom

NEW **[Laerke Ryom Debuts 'Raiments' — Furniture Tailored Like Garments, Copenhagen]** Danish designer shows at Innenkreis gallery. Series moves away from traditional upholstery. Name derives from medieval English word for clothes. Textile-first furniture aligns with Milan Design Week's 2026 material narrative. Copenhagen emerging as secondary launchpad for experimental Scandinavian furniture.

Source: Dezeen

NEW **[Studio RE+N's Floating Pavilion Hovers Above Chinese Tea Mountain]** Stepped platforms descend the slope parallel to tea terraces. Thin white-wing form cantilevers over the landscape. Tea-tourism infrastructure is a growing architectural typology in China's rural economy.

Source: DesignBoom

NEW **[Archmongers Revamps Three Mid-Century Houses on London's Dulwich Estate]** New materials and details injected into 1950s–60s homes. Follows the firm's award-winning Little Brownings project on the same estate. Repeat commissions signal demand from conservation-area homeowners willing to invest in design-led upgrades.

Source: Dezeen

NEW **[Maximum's Clavex Tables — Scaffolding, Glass, Cork, Paint Overspray]** French company builds furniture from four waste products. Retired scaffolding, tempered office glass, wine corks, and industrial paint overspray. Multi-stream waste-to-product models gain traction ahead of EU Ecodesign mandates. Each table unique due to variable inputs.

Source: Core77

DAY 2 **[Nike England World Cup Kit — Texture-Engineered Fabric]** *Flags, lions, and stars engineered into fabric rather than printed. Traditional palette preserved.* England wears the kits at this year's World Cup. Previously: Flags, lions, and stars engineered into fabric rather than printed. Traditional palette preserved. England will wear the kits at this year's World Cup. Structural-graphic integration signals where sportswear R&D is heading. Expect competitors to follow with material-first launches.

Source: Dezeen

DAY 2 **[Verge Select — Weathering-Steel Studio for Painter Janna Watson, Ontario]** *Grey County retreat designed for painter Janna Watson.* Three square volumes fuse into a secluded forest workspace. Corten steel ages with the landscape. Previously: Grey County retreat designed for painter Janna Watson. Three volumes form a secluded forest workspace. Weathering-steel artist studios becoming a recurring typology for rural creative retreats.

Source: Dezeen

DAY 2 **[Venice Biennale — Renovated Central Pavilion, Scarpa Elements Restored]** *Flexible exhibition space reorganised ahead of 61st International Art Exhibition.* Restored Carlo Scarpa elements meet new spatial strategies. Previously: Venice Biennale revealed renovated Central Pavilion with restored Scarpa elements and new flexible layout. Scarpa-meets-contemporary approach sets curatorial tone for 2026 Biennale.

Source: DesignBoom

DAY 2 **[MIDW Resting Pavilion at Osaka Expo — Reclaimed-Island Engineering]** *Pavilion sits on Yumeshima, a reclaimed island.* Soil equivalent to building's weight removed before construction on weak ground. Previously: Pavilion sits on Yumeshima, a reclaimed island. Soil-weight excavation required as prerequisite for construction. Engineering constraints on Yumeshima will inform future large-scale developments on reclaimed sites across Asia-Pacific.

Source: ArchDaily

DAY 2 **[42,914 Civilian Buildings Damaged in Iran — Red Crescent Reports]** *Humanitarian group reported 42,914 civilian buildings damaged, including 36,000+ homes.* Figures are IFRC-affiliated estimates. Previously: Humanitarian group reported 42,914 civilian buildings damaged, including 36,000+ homes. Figures are IFRC-affiliated estimates. Scale signals massive future reconstruction effort. Architecture and engineering firms with Middle Eastern presence should monitor post-conflict frameworks.

Source: Dezeen

DAY 3 **[OMA New Museum Expansion — Dezeen Confirms Week's Top Story]** *OMA completed New Museum expansion at 235 Bowery. Inaugural 'New Humans' exhibition curated by Massimiliano Gioni.* Dezeen's weekly roundup highlights it as lead architecture story. Doubles footprint behind a facade distinct from SANAA's original. Previously: OMA completed New Museum expansion at 235 Bowery. Inaugural 'New Humans' exhibition curated by Massimiliano Gioni. Doubles exhibition and education space including NEW INC incubator. Incubator + exhibition + expansion model sets benchmark for mid-size museum growth.

Sources: Dezeen; ArchDaily

AI & Technology

DAY 2 **[Super Micro Overhauls Compliance After 33% Stock Crash]** *Co-founder Yih-Shyan Liaw charged with conspiring to divert Nvidia servers to China. Liaw resigned. Stock crashed 33%.* Company working to shore up compliance operations. Previously: Co-founder Yih-Shyan Liaw charged with conspiring to divert Nvidia-powered servers to China through southeast Asia. Liaw resigned from the board. Stock crashed 33%. Dell already benefiting as enterprises seek cleaner supply chains. GPU KYC requirements will tighten across server OEMs within 6 months.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[xAI Deploys Engineers to Client Offices to Poach OpenAI, Anthropic Accounts]** *Musk's xAI embedding engineers at prospective enterprise customers.* Tactic targets accounts currently using OpenAI and Anthropic. Previously: Musk's xAI embedding engineers at prospective enterprise customers. Tactic targets accounts currently using OpenAI and Anthropic. White-glove deployment mirrors Palantir's early playbook. Signals xAI pivot to enterprise revenue. Watch for pricing wars over two quarters.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Nvidia GTC Theme: Agentic AI at 'Inflection Point' — GPU Focus Fades]** *LPU is first chip from Nvidia's $20B Groq acquisition. Vera CPU rack also debuted.* Huang declared agentic AI at an inflection point. Less focus on GPU, more on new compute configurations. Previously: Language Processing Unit is first chip from Nvidia's $20B Groq acquisition. Single-core design optimized to accelerate GPU workloads. Vera CPU rack also debuted. LPU+CPU racks signal Nvidia expanding TAM beyond GPUs. AMD and Intel face competitive gap in multi-chip agent infrastructure.

Source: CNBC

DAY 2 **[Thiel's Founders Fund Backs AI Cow Collar Startup Halter at $2B]** *New round would double valuation.* AI-powered livestock collars attract top-tier venture capital. Precision agriculture consolidating fast. Previously: New round would double valuation. AI-powered livestock collars attracting top-tier venture capital. $2B for livestock wearables signals venture appetite for AI beyond software. Founders Fund backing raises visibility for the entire agtech vertical.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[White House AI Framework — Federal Preemption, Child Safety, Light-Touch Rules]** *Seven-point plan urges Congress to preempt state AI laws. Emphasizes innovation over regulation.* Shifts child safety burden toward parents. Enforcement via courts, not new agencies. Previously: Seven-point plan urges Congress to preempt state-level AI regulation. Emphasizes child safety. Shifts enforcement to courts rather than new agencies. Federal clarity timeline is Q4 2026 at earliest. Light-touch framing benefits incumbents over startups on compliance moat.

Sources: The Verge; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Anthropic Files Sworn Declarations — Pentagon Was 'Nearly Aligned' Before Trump Intervention]** *DoD told Anthropic the two sides were close to agreement one week before Trump ended the relationship.* Court filings reveal timeline. DOJ defending the designation at DC Circuit. Previously: DoD filed March 17 brief arguing Anthropic's usage restrictions create supply chain risk. Anthropic denied it could sabotage AI tools during war. Filing undercuts the government's urgency narrative. Government contracting terms now a board-level risk for all frontier AI companies. Watch for settlement signals over 2–3 weeks.

Sources: TechCrunch; Wired

DAY 2 **[Warren, Blumenthal Formally Probe Nvidia-Groq $20B Deal]** *Senate probe targets whether deal structure avoids FTC review.* Probe gains weight now that LPU chip is public. Previously: Senate probe announced targeting whether deal structure avoids FTC review. First LPU chip from the Groq acquisition debuted at GTC. Senate letter could pressure FTC to open formal review. Nvidia's deal structure becomes a template — or cautionary tale — for future AI M&A.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[AI Startups Captured 41% of Carta Venture Dollars — Record Concentration]** *Accel's Arun Mathew flagged 'bubble tendencies.'* AI startups took 41% of $128B raised on Carta last year. Mathew predicts fallout with fewer winners. Previously: Accel partner Arun Mathew flagged 'bubble tendencies' and predicted fewer winners in the next era. 41% concentration is historically extreme. LPs should stress-test AI exposure across fund portfolios. Shakeout likely in 18–24 months.

Sources: TechCrunch; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Google's Project Mariner Staff Shifted — Browser Agents Lose to CLI Tools]** *Google shook up browser agent team as industry pivots to OpenClaw.* Mariner staff moved to higher-priority work. OpenAI walked away from browser-based ChatGPT Agent. Previously: Google shook up its browser agent team as the industry pivots to OpenClaw. OpenAI and Anthropic both investing in CLI-native agents. Browser-based agents losing the standards race to terminal-native platforms. Web automation startups face strategic headwinds.

Source: MediaPost †

Economic & Business Intelligence

NEW **[Iran Selectively Opens Hormuz — Grain Ships, Japanese Vessels Granted Passage]** Tehran allowing grain carriers through. Separately told Japan it will let Japanese vessels transit. Selective access fragments the blockade into bilateral negotiations. Two-tier system keeps oil blocked while food and allied vessels pass. Complicates Western escalation logic. Energy markets stay disrupted; agricultural relief marginal.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

NEW **[Iraq Declares Force Majeure on All Foreign-Operated Oilfields]** Baghdad invoked force majeure as Hormuz blocks crude exports. Directly impacts BP, Shell, ExxonMobil. Revenue, production targets, and capex commitments all frozen. Iraq's 4.5mb/d largely landlocked. Supermajor earnings face material Q2 downgrades.

Source: Reuters

NEW **[EU Energy Chief Orders Early Gas Storage Filling to Avoid Summer Spike]** Commission told member states to start filling immediately. Goal: avoid competitive bidding that spikes summer prices. Early filling compresses the buying window and may paradoxically lift near-term gas prices. TTF forwards likely reprice upward through Q2.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

NEW **[Iran Fires Missiles at UK's Diego Garcia Base — Exceeds Known Capabilities]** Attack on British Indian Ocean Territory significantly exceeds Tehran's known missile range. Stokes European fears about Iran's strategic reach. Capability demonstration reshapes threat calculus for Indian Ocean and European forward bases. Defense spending consensus hardens.

Source: FT

NEW **[Austria Seeks €2B in Budget Cuts — Finance Minister Cites 'Dumb War' Risk]** Finance Minister flagged €1B–€2B consolidation needed. Iran war adding to outlook risks. First EU member to publicly link austerity to war costs. Austria's austerity signals broader EU fiscal stress. War-driven energy costs force similar recalculations across peripheral eurozone economies.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Central Banks Globally Signal Rate Hikes May Be Coming]** Fed, ECB, BoE, BoJ all held this week. All sounded cautious on inflation. Asian central banks shifted to sidelines. SNB signaled willingness to intervene on franc. Synchronized hawkish hold across G10 is the clearest coordinated signal since 2022. Duration risk elevated across all major bond markets.

Sources: Bloomberg; WSJ

NEW **[Janus Living IPO Raises $840M — Shares Jump 18% on Debut]** Seniors-focused REIT priced and traded strongly Friday. Investor appetite for defensive real assets despite war volatility. Strong debut amid broad selloff suggests flight to defensive yield. Healthcare real estate may attract rotation as growth faces rate headwinds.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Amazon-Backed Nuclear Startup X-Energy Files for US IPO]** Advanced reactor developer filed despite war turmoil. Aims to capitalize on rising AI data center power demand. Filing into this volatility signals strong sponsor confidence. Nuclear narrative strengthened by the energy crisis.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[Wall Street's 'Brief Disruption' Bet Breaks — War Enters Fourth Week]** *Markets clung to thesis that Hormuz would reopen quickly. Friday, that narrative collapsed.* Iran selectively opens to grain and Japan but oil remains blocked. Iraq declared force majeure. Trump rejected ceasefire but floated 'winding down.' Previously: Markets had clung to the thesis that Hormuz would reopen quickly. Friday, that narrative collapsed. Iran unwilling to discuss reopening while under attack. Selective Hormuz access and Iraq force majeure deepen the supply shock. Maximum ambiguity persists through Q2.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[EU Braces for Multi-Year Energy Squeeze — 17% Qatar LNG Offline 3–5 Years]** *Iranian attacks knocked out 17% of Qatar's LNG export capacity. IEA chief Birol called this the greatest threat to global energy 'in history.'* EU ordered early gas storage filling. Previously: Iranian attacks knocked out 17% of Qatar's LNG export capacity. Commission proposed lowering gas storage targets. IEA chief Birol called this the greatest threat to global energy 'in history.' Early filling directive accelerates procurement and lifts near-term TTF. Industrial consumers face margin squeeze through summer.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[Fed Rate Hike Odds Surge — 75% Chance by September, Cuts Erased]** *Better-than-even odds of a July hike had emerged. Waller said oil convinced him to hold.* Market pricing hit ~75% for September hike. Traders pushed first cut expectation to 2027. Yields surged 12–15bp Friday. Previously: Better-than-even odds of a July hike had emerged. Waller said the oil shock convinced him to hold. Complete erasure of 2026 cut expectations is the most dramatic repricing since 2022. Duration positioning requires urgent review.

Sources: Reuters; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[US Stocks Post Fourth Straight Losing Week — S&P 500 Down 5% From Peak]** *Major benchmarks dropped to September levels. Russell 2000 first US index in correction.* 'Triple witching' amplified Friday selling. 10-year hit 4.328%, highest since August. Previously: Major benchmarks dropped to September levels. Russell 2000 became first US index in correction. 4.3% on the 10-year is the key Truist threshold. Sustained breach increases equity discount rates. Next support: S&P 500's 200-day moving average.

Sources: Bloomberg; MarketWatch

DAY 2 **[Goldman CEO Solomon Warns Private Credit Risks — 'Cycle Not Repealed']** *Blackstone's flagship fund posted first monthly loss since 2022.* Solomon's annual letter flagged non-bank lending risks. Previously: Blackstone's flagship private credit fund posted first monthly loss since 2022. Loan markdowns drove the loss. Goldman's CEO publicly flagging private credit risk is a signal to LPs. Funds with floating-rate loans to energy-sensitive borrowers most exposed.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[UK Gilt Selloff Deepens — BoE Hawkish Pivot Fuels Rout]** *10-year gilt yield hit 5%, highest since 2008. February borrowing reached £14.3B above forecast.* Markets price 80bp of hikes by year-end — at least three quarter-point rises. Previously: 10-year gilt yield hit 5%, highest since 2008. February borrowing reached £14.3B above forecast. 80bp priced versus pre-war expectation of a cut. UK gilt market in self-reinforcing loop: hawkish BoE → higher yields → worse fiscal math.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[ECB Hike Consensus Builds — JPM, Barclays, Morgan Stanley All Forecast Increases]** *Makhlouf said April hike possible. Villeroy declared ECB 'totally determined.' Traders price 50%+ for April.* JPMorgan and Barclays forecast three hikes to 2.75%. Morgan Stanley expects two to 2.5%. Previously: Makhlouf said an April hike is possible if data warrant it. Villeroy declared the ECB 'totally determined' on inflation. Traders price

50%+ chance of a hike at the April meeting. Three major banks forecasting hikes removes ambiguity. Euro-area front-end rates and peripheral spreads reprice through April 17.

Sources: CNBC; Reuters

DAY 2 **[Dallas Fed — Hormuz Closure Through June Cuts Global GDP by 2.9 Points]** *Dallas Fed modeled the scenario: annualized 2.9pp Q2 reduction.* Vanguard said oil would need ~$150 for the rest of 2026 to induce US recession. Previously: Federal Reserve Bank of Dallas modeled the scenario. Result: annualized 2.9pp reduction in Q2 global growth. Dallas Fed scenario is now the baseline macro risk. Recession probability models for H2 2026 likely jump above 40%.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Reeves Faces 'Very Difficult Budget' — Loses £3B+ of Fiscal Buffer]** *Rising gilt yields erode fiscal headroom.* Gilt selloff could cost Reeves more than a 10th of her buffer. February borrowing hit £14.3B above forecast. Previously: Treasury foresees a painful autumn fiscal event. Rising gilt yields and debt-servicing costs erode fiscal headroom. Higher borrowing costs plus energy inflation compress options to tax hikes or spending cuts. Sterling assets face headwinds through autumn Budget.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

DAY 2 **[Fed's Waller — Oil Shock Changed His Vote From Cut to Hold]** *Waller said surging oil requires a conservative approach.* Revealed he planned to vote for a cut before the war. Still sees cuts possible if labor market weakens. Core PCE at 3.1%. Previously: Waller said surging oil requires a more conservative approach. Weak job market may still warrant cuts later in 2026. Waller's dovish-to-hold shift is the most significant individual FOMC signal. His conversion narrows the path to cuts. FOMC consensus hardens around hold-to-hike.

Sources: Reuters; NYT

DAY 2 **[Diesel at $5/Gallon — Bloomberg Calls It the 'Real Concern']** *US diesel surpassed $5 for only the second time in history.* Fuel powers trucking, agriculture, construction. ~20% of trucking operating costs. Previously: US diesel surpassed $5 for only the second time in history after 2022. $5+ diesel flows into food, freight, and construction costs within 2–4 weeks. Expect CPI passthrough in April–May data.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[JPMorgan Cuts S&P 500 Target on Iran War Uncertainty]** *JPMorgan strategists cut target citing Middle East war.* Upside potential 'more constrained.' Likely triggers wave of sell-side reductions. Previously: JPMorgan strategists cut S&P 500 target citing Middle East war. If oil holds above $100, year-end estimates face further downward revisions across the Street.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[First SPR Barrels Set to Flow — US Expands Supply Measures]** *US issued license permitting sale of stranded Iranian oil on vessels. SPR release announced.* First oil from 172M-barrel draw set to start flowing. Previously: US issued general license permitting sale of stranded Iranian oil on vessels. SPR release announced. Marginal supply additions. Insufficient to offset Hormuz closure. 172M-barrel draw depletes reserves significantly.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Airlines Face Biggest Crisis Since Pandemic — Jet Fuel Fears]** *Middle East war unleashing severe disruption. Fears of jet fuel shortage rattling carriers.* Qantas CEO issued memo assuring supplies into April. Previously: Middle East war unleashing severe disruption. Fears of jet fuel shortage rattling carriers. April assurance implies no visibility beyond. Unhedged carriers face margin destruction. Surcharges or capacity cuts likely within weeks.

Sources: FT; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[SoftBank Plans $500B Ohio AI Data Center Campus]** *CEO Son confirmed the $500B figure.* Gas-fired power plants would supply the facility. Previously: CEO Son said the project would channel $500B into a single campus. Figure is aspirational and likely spans many years. Gas-powered design locks in fossil dependency. Signals AI infrastructure ambition at unprecedented scale.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Electronic Arts $15B Debt Sale Draws $25B Demand]** *$25B investor demand signals strong credit appetite despite volatile markets.* 1.7x oversubscription is a key credit signal. Previously: Sale funds a buyout. $25B investor demand signals strong credit appetite despite volatile markets. Investment-grade credit still functioning. Key data point for leveraged finance pipelines.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[India's RBI Burns $20B+ in FX Reserves This Month Defending Rupee]** *Over $20B spent in March alone. Oil import costs the primary channel.* Reserve burn rate unsustainable beyond months. Previously: Over $20B spent in March alone. Oil import costs are the primary transmission channel. If Hormuz disruption persists, RBI may accept depreciation — adding imported inflation. EM Asia central banks face similar dilemmas.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Canada Rate Hike Bets Intensify — TSX Erases All 2026 Gains]** *Traders had begun pricing more aggressive BoC tightening.* Hawkish peer messaging reinforced bets. TSX confirmed full erasure of YTD gains. Previously: Traders had begun pricing more aggressive BoC tightening as oil surged. If oil stays elevated, April BoC pivot becomes likely. CAD longs may benefit near-term from oil windfall.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[UK Energy Cap Set to Surge 20% — £332 Annual Increase From July]** *Cornwall Insight forecast confirmed.* Rising gas costs the driver. Previously: Cornwall Insight had forecast a 20% summer cap increase. £332 increase hits UK consumer spending directly. Retailers and hospitality face demand destruction. Political pressure on Starmer intensifies through Q2.

Sources: Bloomberg; BBC

DAY 2 **[UK Mortgage Rates 'Very Likely' to Rise as Lenders Reprice]** *Lenders rapidly repricing fixed-rate deals.* Gilt selloff and inflation fears driving the adjustment. Previously: Lenders rapidly repricing fixed-rate deals. BoE expects inflation to reach 3%–3.5% in coming quarters. UK housing faces a rates squeeze. Housebuilders and mortgage lenders face near-term earnings risk.

Source: FT

DAY 2 **[Bowman Holds Three-Cut View — Contrasts With Market Hike Pricing]** *Bowman projected three rate cuts despite oil shock.* Gap between her view and market pricing (75% hike) has never been wider this cycle. Previously: Bowman projected three rate cuts in 2026, contrasting with market hike pricing. Bowman's outlier dovishness highlights deep FOMC divide. Widest gap between a governor's view and market pricing this cycle.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Fitch Cuts New Zealand Credit Outlook to Negative]** *Cited concern about timeline for reining in government debt.* Rating unchanged. Puts NZ on 12–24 month downgrade watch. Previously: Cited concern that reining in government debt will take longer than expected. Adds to global fiscal-stress theme as war-driven energy costs pressure public finances.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Oil Posts Fifth Straight Weekly Gain — Brent ~50% Higher Since War Began]** *Iran struck Qatar's Ras Laffan, damaging world's largest LNG facility. Brent briefly touched $119.* Iraq force majeure adds supply pressure.

Kharg Island seizure plan still under White House debate. Previously: Iran struck Qatar's Ras Laffan, damaging world's largest LNG facility. Brent briefly touched $119. Shell confirmed Pearl GTL damage. Fifth weekly gain with Iraq force majeure compounding losses. Kharg Island debate is the next binary risk event. Ground operation sends crude well above $120.

Sources: Kitco/Reuters; MarketWatch

Private Equity

NEW **[Ecolab Acquires KKR-Backed CoolIT Systems for $4.75B]** Data center liquid cooling company sold to Ecolab. KKR exits as AI infrastructure cooling demand surges. KKR crystallizes a premium exit at AI/thermal intersection. Data center cooling becoming a standalone asset class. Expect follow-on PE activity in adjacent targets.

Source: Law360

NEW **[Apollo and Realty Income Launch $1B Single-Tenant Retail JV]** Apollo commits $1B alongside Realty Income for net-lease retail properties. Deployment into net-lease retail signals conviction that cap rates have peaked. Inflation-linked cash flows attractive in current rate uncertainty.

Source: Law360

NEW **[Abbott to Close $21B Exact Sciences Acquisition Monday]** Abbott confirmed it expects to finalize the cancer-screening deal Friday. Expands diagnostics presence significantly. One of 2026's largest healthcare deals. Cancer diagnostics consolidation accelerates as precision medicine becomes strategic priority for diversified med-tech.

Source: Modern Healthcare †

NEW **[Private Credit Spreads Widen — Thoma Bravo's WWEX Prices at S+575]** WWEX Group's $4.815B unitranche priced at S+575. Led by Ares with 33 lenders. Vista's Nexthink deal at S+550. Market expects further widening. Borrower-friendly repricing wave since late 2023 reversing. Sponsors face materially higher carry costs on new LBOs.

Source: PitchBook

NEW **[Defense Electronics PE Deals Up 93% YoY — 27 Deals in 2025]** PitchBook data: deal count nearly doubled. Total value $1.7B. Activity concentrated in small-to-mid enabling technologies beneath prime contractors. Iran war and geopolitical rearmament reinforce the thesis. Expect sustained activity through 2026 as NATO budgets tilt toward electronics upgrades.

Source: PitchBook

NEW **[Finland PE Investment Hits Record €9.6B — IT Deals Drive Nordic Share]** Total value doubled from 2023. Deal count rose 20% to 228. Finland's share of Nordic PE climbed to 18.3%. Finland's IT sector depth positions it as a growing Nordic target market. Sponsors seeking European tech outside UK/DACH should note the pipeline.

Source: PitchBook

NEW **[Qatar Investment Authority Eyes ~10% Stake in Golden Goose]** QIA preparing to buy into Italian sneaker maker, per Corriere della Sera. Permira took Golden Goose public in 2024. Sovereign interest in PE-backed luxury brand signals valuation floor. QIA diversifying into European consumer luxury amid Gulf war uncertainty.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Trian Doubles Down Against Victory's $8.6B Janus Henderson Bid]** *Trian and General Catalyst had $7.4B take-private deal. Victory countered at $8.6B.* Trian said Friday it sees no clear path for Victory. Cited attrition risk. Expects to close in ~3 months. Previously: Trian and General Catalyst had an existing $7.4B all-cash take-private deal for Janus Henderson. Victory Capital countered with an $8.6B cash-and-stock rival bid. Public rebuttal signals confidence in contractual protections. Janus board faces fiduciary pressure to engage higher bid. Expect Victory response within days.

Source: Reuters

DAY 2 **[KKR-FiberCop €1B Ares Deal — Exchange Buyback Confirmed]** *Italy's largest fixed-line network secured €1B from Ares alongside KKR.* FiberCop buying back telecom exchanges once part of its system. Previously: Italy's largest fixed-line network secured €1B from Ares to repurchase telecom exchanges alongside KKR. Infrastructure debt continues attracting private credit capital even as corporate lending sours.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Echelon Data Centres Owners Weigh Sale — Process Confirmed]** *Dublin-based Echelon owners considering selling part or all stakes.* Bloomberg reports process at early stage. Previously: Dublin-based Echelon owners considering selling part or all stakes. Process at early stage. European DC assets command premium multiples. Any sale attracts hyperscaler-backed consortia and infrastructure PE.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Private Credit Defaults Accelerating — DBRS Expects Pace to Continue]** *Distressed exchanges accounted for 94% of defaults in 12 months through February. PIK and deferred interest rising.* 16% of active ratings sit in CCC-to-C. DBRS expects further weakening. Previously: Morningstar DBRS reported distressed exchanges accounted for 94% of defaults in 12 months through February. PIK and deferred interest schemes rising. Sponsors holding CCC-rated credits face forced restructurings. LP markdowns likely over next two quarters.

Source: PitchBook

DAY 6 **[Blackstone BCRED Posts First Monthly Loss Since 2022]** *BCRED allowed $3.7B in Q1 redemptions from $82B fund.* Loan markdowns drove first negative return in over three years. One of clearest signs of weakening in $1.8T private credit market. Previously: BCRED allowed $3.7B in Q1 redemptions from $82B fund. First monthly loss since 2022 compounds withdrawal pressure. Combined with accelerating defaults and Solomon's warning, private credit sentiment is shifting. Watch for contagion to other semi-liquid vehicles.

Sources: Bloomberg; FT

Startups

NEW **[AI-Native VC Funds Show Strong Early IRRs — Paper Gains Caveat Applies]** Younger AI-focused funds report high initial returns. PitchBook warns markups from follow-on rounds inflate IRR. 2021/2020 vintages lack equivalent AI exposure. LPs should discount early IRR in sub-3-year funds. True signal comes from 2022–2023 vintages reaching DPI milestones in 2027.

Source: TechCrunch

NEW **[Top Startup Acquirers — CRM, OpenAI, Snowflake Lead 3-Year Tally]** Crunchbase identified 79 companies acquiring three or more venture-backed startups in three years. CRM platforms, OpenAI, and Snowflake among most acquisitive. Serial acquirers signal consolidation intensifying in AI and data infrastructure. Expect acqui-hire pace to accelerate through H1 2026.

Source: Crunchbase News †

NEW **[Nvidia's $20B Groq Deal Draws Senate Antitrust Scrutiny]** Warren and Blumenthal probe whether licensing structure avoids merger review. Concern: illegal consolidation of AI compute market power. If Senate pressure triggers FTC review, expect 6–9 month delay. Sets precedent for how Big Tech structures AI deals to avoid Hart-Scott-Rodino thresholds.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[PitchBook AI Map — Vertical Apps Led With 4,609 Deals in 2025]** Vertical AI outpaced horizontal platforms (1,821 deals). Autonomous machines posted record Q4. Semiconductor deal value grew 82% YoY. Deal concentration in vertical AI confirms enterprise adoption shifting to industry-specific deployment. VCs underweight in autonomous machines may miss the next breakout segment.

Source: PitchBook

NEW **[Bluesky Raised $100M Series B — 43M Users on Decentralized Protocol]** Funding disclosed from last April. ~500 interoperable third-party apps. 1,000+ apps built on AT Protocol weekly. Developer velocity on AT Protocol signals genuine traction beyond user vanity metrics.

Source: MediaPost †

NEW **[SPACs Return — Deep Tech and Quantum Target Faster Public Listings]** Quantum VC funding tripled to €5B+ in 2025. Danish VC 55 North launched €300M vehicle. SPAC mergers complete in 3–4 months vs. 6–12 for IPOs. Expect 3–5 quantum SPAC announcements in H1 2026. Sponsor quality separates viable deals from 2021-era repeats.

Source: PitchBook

NEW **[Accel Partner Flags 'Bubble Tendencies' in AI — Fewer Winners Ahead]** Arun Mathew calls current cycle a 'reinvention of work.' Warns of market fallout. Productivity gains concentrating in fewer companies. Accel managing ~$50B+ AUM adds weight. Late-stage AI investors face multiple compression within 12 months.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Amazon Acquires Rivr — Stair-Climbing Delivery Robot Startup]** Bezos and Amazon previously invested. Deal signals commitment to autonomous doorstep delivery. Fills last-50-feet gap in Amazon's delivery automation. Stair-climbing targets dense urban housing. Competitive signal for Agility Robotics, Serve Robotics.

Source: TechCrunch

NEW **[Weekly Top VC Rounds Skew to Cybersecurity and AI Infrastructure]** Security and privacy startups dominated this week's largest US deals. AI infrastructure, biotech, and robotics also attracted sizable rounds. Cybersecurity prominence reflects enterprise budget shifts as AI-agent attack surfaces expand.

Source: Crunchbase News †

DAY 2 **[Kalshi Temporarily Banned in Nevada — Gaming License Dispute]** *Prediction market raised $1B+ at $22B valuation. Now faces regulatory friction.* Judge signed restraining order blocking event contracts for up to two weeks. Previously: Prediction market operator raised $1B+ at $22B valuation. Now faces regulatory friction as states push back. State-by-state challenges threaten Kalshi's national scale thesis. Watch for similar actions in NJ and PA within 30 days.

Sources: TechCrunch; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Earendil Labs $787M — Hong Kong IPO Under Consideration]** *US-headquartered, China-rooted biotech secured one of the largest AI pharma rounds.* Endpoints News reports Hong Kong listing under consideration. Previously: US-headquartered, China-rooted biotech secured one of the largest private rounds in AI pharma. Hong Kong listing path gives access to China-proximate capital. Signals AI-biotech IPO window opening in APAC despite US volatility.

Source: Endpoints News †

DAY 2 **[Bezos $100B Manufacturing AI Fund — SWF Outreach Underway]** *Amazon founder targets chipmaking, defense, and aerospace companies. Project Prometheus raising up to $6.2B separately.* Bezos meeting potential investors in Singapore and the Middle East. Previously: Amazon founder targets companies in chipmaking, defense, and aerospace. Separate Project Prometheus AI startup raising up to $6.2B. Sovereign outreach confirms this is not speculative. Largest AI-for-industry vehicle ever attempted. Competition for industrial acquisition targets will intensify.

Sources: TechCrunch; Industrial Equipment News †

IPO & Exit Climate

DAY 2 **[Vincorion Rallies in Frankfurt IPO — Defense Listings Catching Structural Bid]** *German military power-systems supplier listed as Iran war fuels defense demand.* Shares rallied in trading debut. Previously: German military power-systems supplier listed in Frankfurt as Iran war fuels defense demand. European defense IPOs catching structural bid as NATO rearms. Could pull forward other defense-adjacent listings through Q2.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[SpaceX IPO Complexity Deepens — NASA Elevates Starship Role]** *PitchBook flagged extreme pricing difficulty for sub-4% float on $300B+ valuation.* NASA revised moon plans, reducing Boeing's role and elevating Starship. Government dependency adds valuation support and regulatory complexity. Previously: PitchBook flagged extreme pricing difficulty for a sub-4% float on $300B+ valuation. Musk-driven sentiment shifts would hit a narrow order book. Thin float plus Musk governance premium makes this the most complex large-cap listing in modern history.

Sources: PitchBook; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[X-Energy IPO Filing Confirmed — $100M Offering in Pipeline]** *X-Energy filed for US IPO on Wednesday. JP Morgan lead confirmed.* Renaissance Capital lists it among this week's pipeline additions. Previously: X-Energy filed for a US IPO on Wednesday despite war-driven volatility. Bloomberg confirmed JP Morgan lead. Data-center power narrative remains durable. Pricing tests whether energy-infrastructure stories cut through risk aversion.

Sources: Renaissance Capital †; Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Trend Signal — Exit Window Narrows as Credit Cracks Appear]** *War bifurcated IPO window: defense and asset-backed clearing; growth stalled. Russell 2000 in correction.* Blackstone credit fund posted first loss. JPMorgan cut S&P targets. Janus Living and Vincorion debuted strong. SPACs re-emerge for deep tech. Growth listings face $5 diesel, hike bets, and S&P at six-month lows. Previously: War bifurcated IPO window: defense and asset-backed stories clearing; growth and EM listings stalled. Russell 2000 hit correction. FII outflows from India exceeded $8B. Three-lane market: defense/infrastructure clears, asset-backed REITs price at discount, everything else waits. Q3 earliest for broad reopening absent Hormuz resolution.

Sources: Bloomberg; Bloomberg

DAY 3 **[Swarmer 1,000% Surge Reflects Defense-AI Investor Appetite]** *Surged 1,000% in two days — best US debut in nearly a year.* Bloomberg: reveals appetite at the intersection of geopolitics, defense tech, and AI. Previously: Swarmer surged 1,000% in two days — best US stock debut in nearly a year. Defense-AI micro-caps drawing speculative capital. Could accelerate more defense startup listings. Micro-cap volatility this extreme typically fades within weeks.

Source: Bloomberg

Real Estate & Property

NEW **[Decron Properties Lands $83M Fannie Mae Refi for Simi Valley Multifamily]** 398-unit River Ranch Apartments. Garden-style complex in Southern California. ~$208K/unit. Agency financing for suburban SoCal multifamily reflects continued GSE appetite for stabilized garden-style assets.

Source: Commercial Observer

NEW **[NextEra Plans Up to 10 GW of Gas-Fired Generation in Texas and Pennsylvania]** Trump approved expansion. Data center boom cited as driver. Massive buildout signals power constraint for DC development addressed at utility scale. Land near planned sites in TX/PA will reprice for data center use.

Source: Bloomberg

NEW **[Jonathan Rose Buys 126-Unit Inwood Affordable Housing for $53M]** Acquired 210 Sherman Avenue from Related Companies. Eighth acquisition for Rose Affordable Housing Preservation Fund VI. ~$420K/unit. Institutional appetite for affordable preservation strategies remains robust despite broader multifamily softness.

Source: Commercial Observer

NEW **[Bain Capital Provides $117.5M Refi for Wynwood Multifamily]** Floating-rate bridge loan for Fisher Brothers' 308-unit Joule House at 2200 NW First Avenue. Completed September. ~$381K/unit. Bridge financing signals lease-up in progress. Miami rental demand remains a magnet despite rising insurance costs.

Source: Commercial Observer

NEW **[Diesel at $5/Gallon — Direct Hit to CRE Construction and Logistics]** Iran war pushes diesel to levels last seen during Russia's 2022 Ukraine invasion. ~20% of trucking operating costs. Pro formas underwritten at lower fuel assumptions face immediate pressure. Expect construction delays and higher tenant pass-throughs in industrial leases.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Activist Litt Withdraws First Industrial REIT Board Bid]** *Land & Buildings founder pulled board nomination.* Says he can push for change more effectively from outside. Previously: Land & Buildings founder Jonathan Litt pulled his board nomination at First Industrial Realty Trust. Withdrawal likely reflects insufficient proxy support. Litt retains options to re-engage at next annual meeting.

Source: Bloomberg

DAY 2 **[Starwood Pays $166.8M for Fairfax County Data Center Land]** *Fairfax County approved sale of police training campus parcel at ~$4M/acre.* ~One-third of 128-acre campus at 3721 Stonecroft Boulevard sold to Starwood affiliate. Previously: Fairfax County approved sale of police training campus parcel to Starwood affiliate for data center development at approximately $4M per acre. Confirmed pricing reinforces NoVA land premium for DC-zoned parcels. Public-asset monetization for data centers is a template other jurisdictions will follow.

Source: Commercial Observer

Alternative Assets

NEW **[Kearney 2026 Luxury Outlook — 2%–4% Growth After Price-Hike Reset]** Forecast frames 2026 as a test of which houses used the reset productively. Brands recalibrating after aggressive increases. Modest growth masks divergence. Disciplined brands (Hermès, Cucinelli) outperform. Watch-and-jewelry categories face Middle East disruption headwinds.

Source: MediaPost †

NEW **[GlenDronach Drops 56-Year-Old Single Malt — $49,000]** Highland distillery released its oldest expression. Limited availability targets ultra-premium collectors. Ultra-aged single malts outperform broader luxury. GlenDronach age-statements historically appreciate on secondary markets.

Source: Robb Report †

NEW **[Ferrari F40 — Appreciation Shows No Sign of Slowing]** Last production model under Enzo Ferrari's direction. Market analysis confirms continued upward trajectory. Blue-chip supercars benefit from UHNW diversification in geopolitical volatility. Sub-10K-mile examples likely test new highs at major auctions this year.

Source: Robb Report †

Operational Calendar

CONFIRMED EVENTS

21 March (today) — Options 'Triple Witching' Expiration

Quarterly expiration of stock options, index options, and index futures.

Source: Benzinga †

18 March (this week) — Federal Reserve FOMC Decision — Rates Unchanged

Fed held rates. Powell said tariffs should be one-time inflation issue. Sticks with single 2026 cut despite higher inflation.

Source: Reuters

19 March (this week) — ECB Holds Rates — Deposit Facility at 2.00%

Held at 2.00%. War poses upside inflation risks, downside growth risks. JPM and Barclays now expect April hike.

Sources: Forex Factory †; Reuters

19 March (this week) — Bank of England Holds Rates at 3.75%

Held unanimously. Bailey advised caution on hike interpretation. Goldman pushed BoE cut forecast to 2027.

Sources: Reuters; CNBC

19 March (this week) — 'Super Thursday' — BoJ, Riksbank, SNB Decisions

All delivered alongside BoE and ECB. Central banks grappling with Iran war and energy prices.

Source: CNBC

19 March (this week) — U.S. Treasury Month-End Supply Announcement

$69B 2-year, $70B 5-year, $44B 7-year, $28B 2-year FRNs, $19B 10-year TIPS.

Source: Mortgage News Daily †

ON THE HORIZON

29-30 April — ECB Governing Council Meeting — Rate Hike Discussion Expected

Sources say ECB may begin debating tightening. Hike more likely in June unless oil hits $200.

Sources: Kitco / Reuters; Reuters

CONTEMPORARY ART SPOTLIGHT

Sam Doyle — Gullah Visionary on Found Wood and Tin

Sam Doyle spent decades on South Carolina's Saint Helena Island painting narrative portraits of his Gullah community on discarded materials — house paint on found wood, roofing tin, whatever was at hand. Discovered late in life, his work bridges folk tradition and contemporary art. His paintings appear at the Outsider Art Fair in New York, where the field asserts parity with the mainstream.

BORN 1906, SAINT HELENA ISLAND, SC · DIED 1985 · SMITHSONIAN AMERICAN ART MUSEUM, HIGH MUSEUM · OUTSIDER ART FAIR 2026

[Why it matters] Doyle's work sits at the intersection of cultural documentation and raw aesthetic power. His portraits record Gullah life — healers, athletes, community figures — in a tradition with almost no other visual chronicler. Self-taught art has moved from curiosity to serious market category. The Outsider Art Fair's continued prominence signals durable collector appetite.

[Current peg] Doyle's narrative portraits are a highlight of the 2026 Outsider Art Fair in New York. The fair draws critical attention for proving that autodidact artists deserve equal recognition — a thesis Doyle's paintings embody viscerally.

[Historical context] Born 1906 on Saint Helena Island, one of the Sea Islands off South Carolina. He began painting in the 1940s using house paint on found wood and tin to create portraits of local figures and Gullah life. The Gullah people, descendants of enslaved West Africans, maintained distinct cultural traditions on the isolated Sea Islands — traditions Doyle captured with an immediacy no trained ethnographer matched.

[One thing to know] Doyle's paintings are simultaneously historical documents of a disappearing culture and formally inventive works — a combination making them increasingly coveted as the boundary between 'outsider' and 'contemporary' dissolves.

Sources: The Art Newspaper; Hyperallergic

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† Source not yet in our verified index. Accuracy has been checked programmatically but editorial vetting of this outlet is pending.

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